

rates, and audio channels. The format is very popular on Apple platforms, and is widely used in professional programs that process digital audio waveforms. The format was co-developed by Apple Computer based on Electronic Arts' Interchange File Format (IFF). There is also the AIFF-Compressed (AIFF-C or AIFC) format, which supports compression ratios as high as 6:1.

AIFF is one of the two most-used audio file formats on Mac operating systems. The other is Sound Designer II (SDII).

The extension for AIFF is .aif when used on a PC.

AU

The .au file format, originally by Sun, isn't widely supported outside the UNIX community. "AU" is short for "audio." It is the standard audio file format for the Java programming language.

2.4 Compressed Lossless Formats

Lossless compression is a compression technique in which data can be decompressed back to its original form without any loss. The decompressed file and the original are identical. For example, ZIP is used to compress documents etc.; there are similar compression techniques for audio and video. Apple Lossless, WMA Lossless and FLAC are examples of lossless compression applied to CD audio. These methods can reduce a full audio CD only to about half its original size.

A word about containers is in order here. A container format is a file format that can contain various types of data, compressed in a manner of standardised codecs. The container file is used to be able to identify and interleave the different data types. Simpler container formats can contain different types of audio codecs, while more advanced container formats can support audio, video, subtitles, chapters, and metadata, along with the synchronisation information needed to play back the various streams together.